Supplementary Materials

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A Materials and Methods

A.1 Media outlet slant

We measure outlet slant using the estimates from Bakshy et al. [2015]; henceforth BMA. The BMA score reflects the self-reported ideology of an outlet's online audience. Each article produced by an outlet is given a score from -2 to 2, depending on the average ideology of users sharing it on Facebook. Articles shared mainly by liberals get negative scores, while those shared by conservatives receive positive scores. The outlet's BMA score is the average of all its articles' scores.

A.2 Citations of research by media outlets

We use Altmetric to construct our media citation data. Altmetric is a bibliometric database that scrapes the websites of thousands of major news outlets every day, counting every instance that a scientific paper is mentioned. Altmetric began

scraping news sites in early 2013, and we conducted our latest search in 2025.

Most citations identified by the Altmetric scraping tool are from news articles that include hyperlinks to scientific journal websites papers or DOIs. A minority of citations are also identified via text mining. For a citation to be identified via text mining, the news article must include the scientist's name, a publication date, and the name of the publishing journal. Some prominent news outlets have few observations or are missing from the Altmetric database (for example, the Wall Street Journal). The reason is that Altmetric cannot scrape websites with restricted content such as paywalls.[1]

Many news organizations publish stories written by journalists at independent organizations, such as the Associated Press (AP). An article from an AP reporter about a topic of national interest might appear in dozens of local newspapers. Since individual news outlets have relatively little agency over the content that appears in these syndicated articles, we restrict our sample to articles that are only published in a single news outlet. In particular, we drop all observations for which multiple news articles share an identical title.

We *a priori* exclude two websites—*globalresearch.ca* and *iflscience.com*—that specialize in science coverage. We also drop news outlets that cover fewer than 20 scientific articles. Our final sample consists of 139 media outlets.

[1]Source: Personal correspondence with Altmetric

A.3 Scientific papers

Our primary data source for scientific articles is Dimensions [Herzog et al., 2020]. Dimensions is a large bibliometric database that aggregates information on published scientific research across the world. Using their API, we downloaded the scientific papers published each day from 2015 to 2023.[2]

For each paper, we collect data on authors: names, university affiliations, fields, and locations. We also collect paper-level variables such as field of research, journal of publication, and year of publication. Last, we collect information on different quality measures of research: number of scientific citations, journal impact, research funding, and patent citations.

A.3.1 Construction and Interpretation of Quality Index

In our analysis, we use the aforementioned measures to capture the scientific quality of an article. In general, it is challenging to define and measure the quality of science. The key reason is that the quality of a scientific article is multifaceted. For example, scientific quality can be defined based on impact, plausibility, novelty, practical applicability, or relevance. Different measures captures different notions of quality. Any single measure of quality will likely miss some important notions of quality.

Thus, we combine these different measures into an index using a principal component analysis (PCA). Our index is based on the number of scientific citations, the

[2]Due to rate limitations, we restricted our query to 1000 articles each day. In the rare instances with more than a thousand articles published in a day, we include the 1000 scientific articles with the most academic citations.

quality of the journal, the research funding, and the patent citations for a scientific article. These measures capture quality from different perspectives. Scientific citations capture relevance from the perspective of other scientists. Research funding captures potential value from the perspective of the sponsor. Patent citations capture the practical applicability of a scientific article. Our index is the first principal component of this array of measures.

We contend that these measures capture a wide range of quality criteria and our index provides a low-dimensional variable to capture these criteria. We emphasize that we are constructing a statistical measure (and not a normative one) that helps us coarsely distinguish between low and high quality research. We do not take a normative stance on this measure, but rather aggregate commonly used and widely accepted measures of scientific quality.

A.4 Political Ideology of Individuals

We use the Database on Money, Ideology, and Elections (DIME) [Bonica, 2016] to construct ideology scores for scientists. DIME compiles public data on political contributions to U.S. politicians at the federal, state, and local levels from 1976–2014. The donation behavior of each contributor is summarized by a *Campaign Finance (CF) Score*, which places the contributor on a one-dimensional left-right scale Bonica [2014].

A.5 Linking DIME and Dimensions

We link DIME to scientists we observe in Dimensions. First, we identify a set of target individuals in DIME. We drop all DIME contributors whose most recent donation was earlier than 2006. Excluding these observations limits noise, since people who donated in the distant past are unlikely to be writing scientific papers in the time period we study. Next, we construct subsamples of recent contributors whose occupations indicate that they are likely to be researchers: individuals whose self-reported occupation is "professor", "scientist", "student", "physician", "doctor", or "researcher". Our final sample includes $600,005$ donors.

Similarly, starting from the Dimensions sample of authors, we construct a sample of unique scientists. We restricted the sample to researchers who are affiliated with an institution in the U.S. and wrote at least one scientific article that was covered by at least one media outlet. In total, we include $807,285$ scientists.

Our linking procedure proceeds as follows. We link scientists and donors according to their names. Specifically, we computed Levenshtein distances between scientist names and donor names. Then, we restrict to all pairs of scientists and donors where the name distance is less than or equal to one. Among these possible pairs, we select

- links where the scientist matches exactly (distance = 0) to a unique donor
- links where the scientist matches exactly on name and US state

We are able to assign a CF score to $47,290$ scientists (approximately 6% of scientist sample) using our procedure.

Finally, we transform our individual-level ideology scores to paper-level scores. We define a paper's CF Score to be the average CF Score of the papers' authors for whom a link existed in DIME. The final linked sample consists of $82,693$ scientific papers with CF Scores.

A.5.1 Validation

We conducted a manual audit to evaluate our linking procedure. We randomly sampled 1,000 scientists who were linked to a donor using our procedure. For each scientist, we conducted manual searches of the web and the DIME dataset to determine any true donor matches. We use these manually linked records as the ground truth against which we evaluate our linking procedure.

We successfully verified 70.6% of matches as true positives and 25.3% as false positives. For 4.1% there was insufficient information to either confirm or refute the match.

A.5.2 Discussion of potential biases from measurement of paper ideology

Noisy Measure: CF Score is an imperfect proxy for scientist ideology for two reasons. First, noise in the linking procedure creates some false positives. Second, our measure of paper slant only considers the slant of authors who have CF scores. The linked authors' influence on paper ideology might be overwhelmed by the influence of the rest of the team. We expect such noise in our measure of scientist ideology to attenuate our estimates of alignment preferences towards zero.

Nonrepresentative sample: All scientists in our linked sample have donated to

a political campaign. Given that the decision to donate to political campaigns is unlikely to be random, our sample may not be representative of the population of scientists. In particular, these scientists may have stronger ideological beliefs than the median scientist.

B Descriptive statistics

B.1 Media outlets

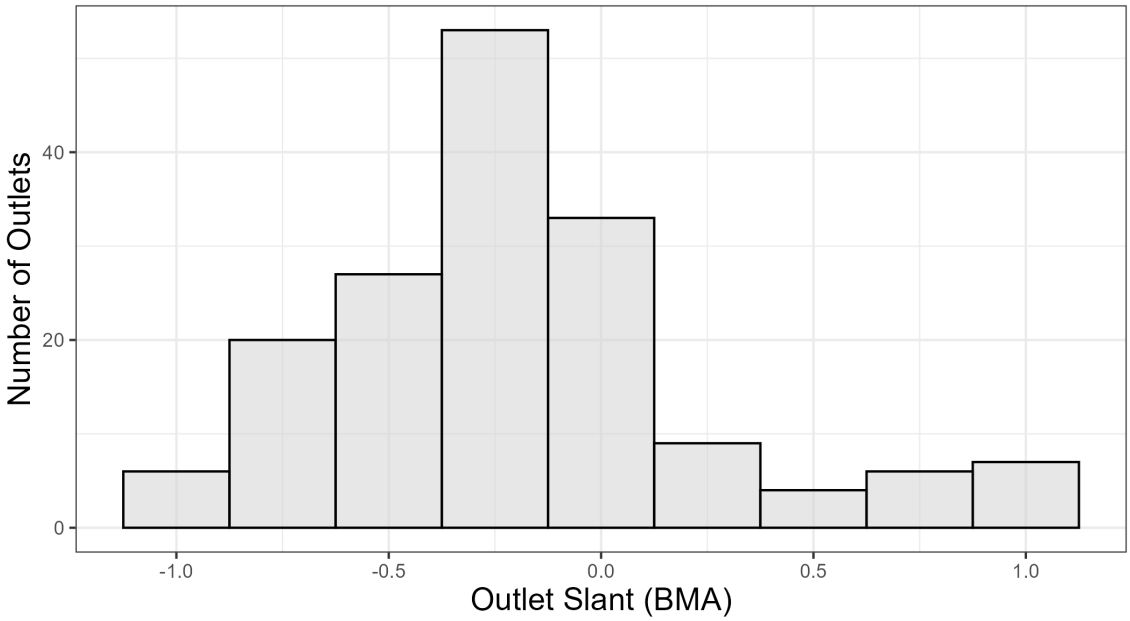
We begin by providing concrete examples of outlets in our sample. Table S1 lists the 10 outlets that covered the most articles. The largest outlets in our sample include large news aggregators like Yahoo! News, national newspapers like New York Times, national magazines like Forbes, and international outlets like BBC. The majority of the outlets in Table S1 are left-leaning. Figure S1 shows that this is also true in the full sample.

Table S1: Examples of outlets in sample

Outlet	Scientific Articles Covered	BMA Slant
msn.com	118926	-0.08
news.yahoo.com	113376	0.05
finance.yahoo.com	26140	0.08
forbes.com	23250	0.06
dailymail.co.uk	23199	0.29
nytimes.com	20345	-0.55
theguardian.com	17965	-0.57
washingtonpost.com	17035	-0.26
bbc.co.uk	14322	-0.33
edition.cnn.com	12518	-0.26

Notes: The table presents the top ten outlets by the number of scientific articles covered. The first column lists the outlet name. The second column lists the number of scientific articles covered. The third column lists the outlet slant as measured by the BMA score.

Figure S1: Distribution of outlet ideology



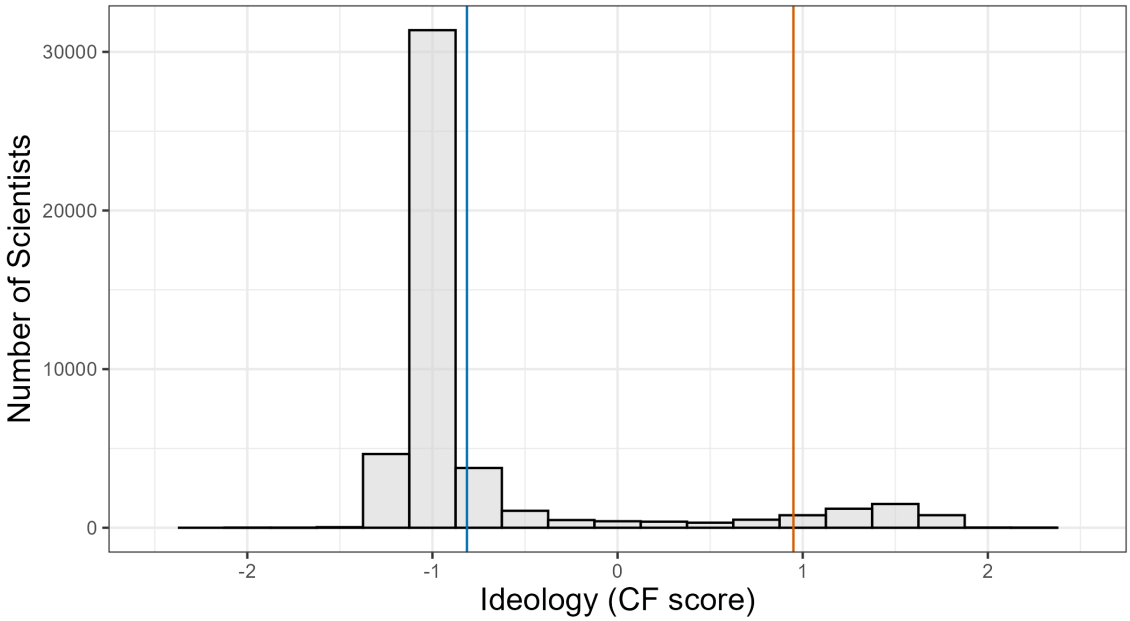
Notes: The figure presents the histogram of outlets by outlet slant. The $x-$axis represents the outlet slant as measured by the BMA score. The $y-$axis represents the number of outlets.

B.2 Ideology of scientists and fields of science

In Figure S2, we present the distribution of the CF Scores of the linked scientists. Most scientists in our sample are liberal. The ideological distribution of scientists in our sample is similar to the ideological distribution of all scientists in the US [Bonica, 2014].

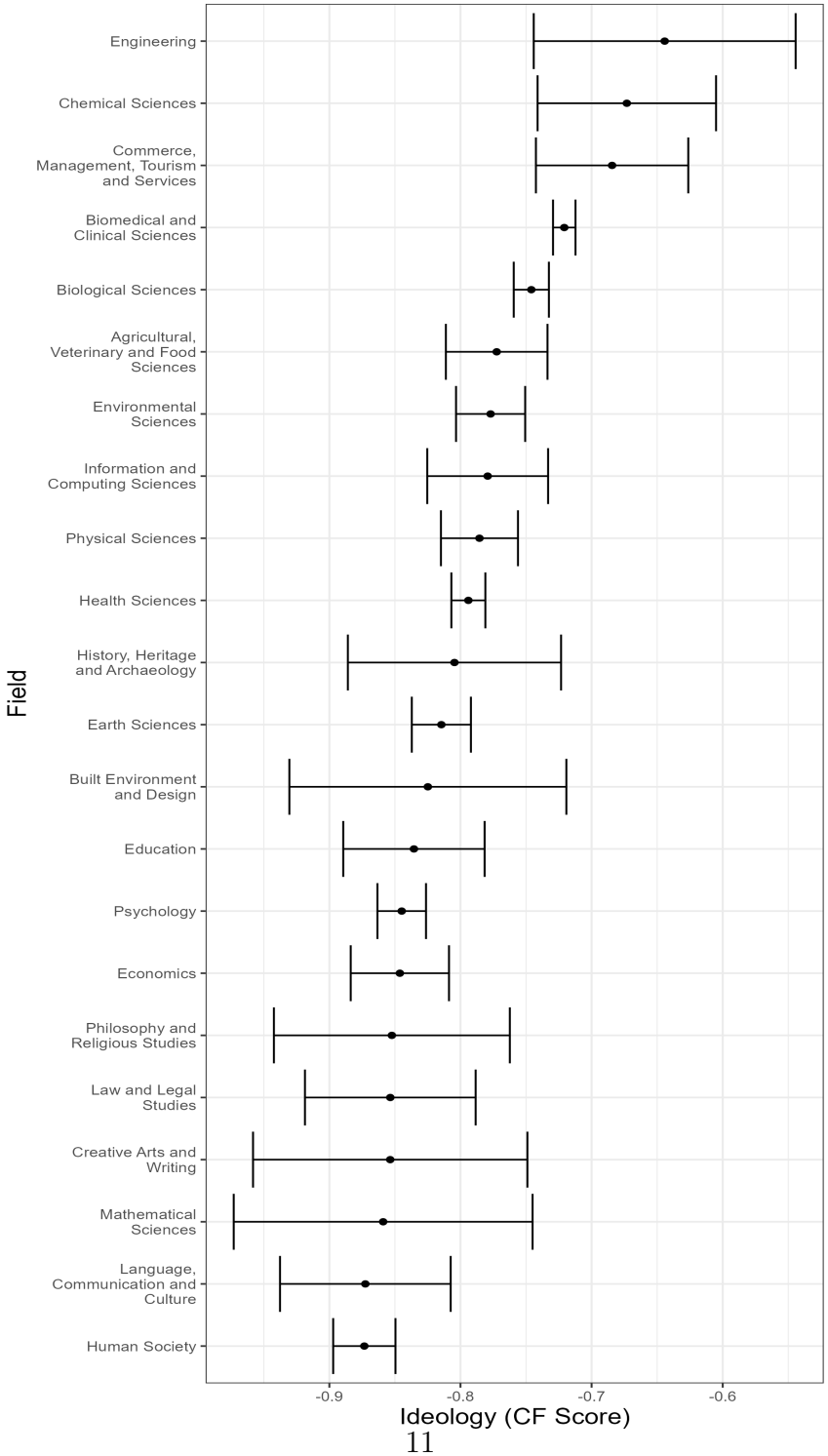
Figure S3 presents the mean ideology of papers across different scientific fields. Note that all fields, on average, are liberal-leaning. However, there is still considerable heterogeneity across fields. Fields like Business Science and Agriculture Science are more conservative relative to fields like Communications and Culture.

Figure S2: Distribution of scientist ideology



Notes: The figure presents the distribution of ideology for linked scientists using our donations-based measure. The $x-$axis represents the scientist's ideology as measured by the CF Score. The $y-$axis represents the number of scientists. The blue and red vertical lines present the CF Score of the median Democratic and the median Republic senator, respectively.

Figure S3: Mean Ideology of Scientists by Field



Notes: The figure presents differences in mean ideology across fields of science. The $x-$axis represents ideology as measured by the CF Score. The $y-$axis represents different scientific fields. The points denoted the mean CF score and the lines denote the 95% confidence intervals for each field.

C Linear probability models

We estimate models of the following type on the set of all **o**utlet-**p**aper pairs (o, p):

$$Y_{op} = \beta\, a(I_o, I_p) + \gamma X_{op} + \epsilon_{op}\,, \tag{1}$$

where Y_{op} is an indicator for whether the paper was covered by the outlet at least once between 2015-2023, $a(I_o, I_p)$ is the ideological alignment between outlet ideology I_o and paper ideology I_p, X_{op} represents controls, and ϵ_{op} represents idiosyncratic errors. Our primary measure of alignment $a(I_o, I_p)$ is the absolute value of the difference in ideology scores for the paper and outlet $a(I_o, I_p) = |I_o - I_p|$. To aid with interpretation, we standardize the measure to have a mean of 0 and a standard deviation of 1. Our results are robust to alternative alignment measures (see Section D.1). The parameter β captures the association between alignment and coverage probability, conditional on controls X_{op}. In all specifications, our controls X_{op} include fixed effects that flexibly control for outlet-specific or field-specific features over time.

We present estimates in Table S2. Column (1) includes Field-Year and Outlet fixed effects. Columns (2) builds on the previous specification and includes more granular Field-Outlet fixed effect. In Columns (3) and (4), we control for non-political paper features using paper fixed effects and our quality index, respectively.

Table S2: Parametric estimates of alignment association (LPMs)

Dependent Variable:	Coverage Probability			
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Variables				
Alignment	0.0010^{***}	0.0009^{***}	0.0009^{***}	0.0001^{**}
	(6.43×10^{-5})	(6.42×10^{-5})	(8.73×10^{-5})	(6.53×10^{-5})
Quality (PCA)				0.0071^{***}
				(3.97×10^{-5})
Fixed-effects				
Field-Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Outlet	Yes		Yes	
Field-Outlet		Yes		Yes
Paper			Yes	
Fit statistics				
Observations	8,757,509	8,757,509	8,757,509	8,513,738
R^2	0.08569	0.09256	0.13144	0.09578
Dependent variable mean	0.02056	0.02056	0.02056	0.02066

IID standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Notes: The table presents the parameter estimates of the linear probability model defined in Equation 1 for different sets of controls. An observation is an outlet-paper pair. The parameter of interest is β, which captures the extent to which ideological alignment a_{op} between an outlet and a paper is associated with coverage probability. Alignment $a(I_o, I_p)$ is the standardized absolute value of the difference in the ideology of the paper and outlet. We only include papers that were cited by at least one outlet.

D Robustness checks

D.1 Alternate alignment measures

In our main analysis, we define alignment between an outlet and a paper as the absolute value of the difference in the ideology $a(I_o, I_p) = |I_o - I_p|$. A potential measurement issue is that the BMA score and CF Scores are on different scales. Even though 0 represents the ideological center for both measures (and so the signs of the measures are consistent), the magnitudes are incommensurate. To assuage these concerns, we employ two other measures of alignment.

Our first alternate measure compares relative ideological positions. For each outlet, we estimate the quantile of their ideology in the distribution outlet ideologies $q(I_o)$. We apply the same procedure for scientific papers $q(I_p)$.[3] Our relative alignment measure is the absolute value of the difference between these quantiles $a_q(I_o, I_p) = |q(I_o) - q(I_p)|$. By construction, the scales of the quantile measures are commensurate. In this measure, an outlet is perfectly aligned with a paper if both fall at the same point in their corresponding ideological distributions. Note that the ideological distribution of scientific ideology is left-skewed compared to that of outlet ideology. Therefore, a paper that is as conservative as an outlet on the relative scale will be more liberal on the absolute scale. We emphasize that there is no simple mapping between these two alignment measures as they capture different notions of alignment. Our second measure is a binary measure of alignment $a_b(I_o, I_p) = 1\{\text{sign}(I_o) = \text{sign}(I_p)\}$: an outlet and paper are aligned if they are both

[3] Formally, $\mathbb{P}(I > I_o) = q(I_o)$, where I is distributed according to the ideology distribution of outlets.

liberal (conservative); otherwise, they are not aligned. This measure only relies on the sign of the ideology and not the magnitude. This measure is invariant to any scale changes in the ideology measure. However, there is a loss of information with this measure, since it is a coarser measure of alignment.

Table S3 presents estimates of alignment preferences using these alternative measures. The regression specification is that defined in Equation 1. We include field-year and field-outlet fixed effects in all specifications. We also include either outlet or outlet-field fixed effects. Across all regression, we consistently find positive and quantitatively meaningful alignment preferences. These results are significant at all conventional levels. In summary, the association of alignment with coverage is not driven by any particular definition of alignment. As one would expect, the interpretation and magnitude of these alignment preferences do vary across these different definitions.

Table S3: Alignment associations using alternate alignment Measures

Dependent Variable:	Coverage Probability	
Model:	(1)	(2)
Variables		
Alignment Quantile (Relative Scale)	0.0027^{***}	
	(0.0002)	
Aligned (Binary Scale)		0.0009^{***}
		(7.63×10^{-5})
Fixed-effects		
Field-Year	Yes	Yes
Field-Outlet	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics		
Observations	8,757,509	8,757,509
R^2	0.09255	0.09255
Dependent variable mean	0.02056	0.02056

IID standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

Notes: The table presents the parameter estimates of the linear probability model defined in Equation 1 for different sets of controls and measures of alignment. Each observation in the model is an outlet-paper pair. The parameter of interest is β which captures the extent to which ideological alignment a_{op} between an outlet and a paper is associated with coverage probability. In columns (1) and (2), alignment $a_q(I_o, I_p)$ is the absolute value of the difference in the ideology quantile of the paper and outlet and in columns (3) and (4), alignment $a_b(I_o, I_p)$ is an indicator which is equal to 1 if both the paper and outlet are Liberal (conservative). We only include papers that were cited by at least one outlet. All columns include field-year and paper fixed effects. Columns (1) and (3) include outlet fixed effects. Columns (2) and (4) include outlet-field fixed effects.

D.2 Parametric quality analysis

We examine how coverage probability depends on alignment and different quality measures. We estimate the following linear LPMs

$$Y_{op} = \beta\, a(I_o, I_p) + \alpha\, q_p + \gamma\, X_{op} + \epsilon_{op}\,, \tag{2}$$

where Y_{op} is an indicator for whether the paper was covered by the outlet at least once between 2015-2023, $a(I_o, I_p)$ is the ideological alignment between outlet ideology I_o and paper ideology I_p, q_p is the quality of paper p, X_{op} represents controls, and ϵ_{op} represents idiosyncratic errors. We include field-year fixed effects and field-outlet fixed effects as controls. We examine four measures of quality: number of academic citations, amount of research grants, number of patent citations, and journal impact.

The results are presented in Table S4. Across all specifications, we find a positive association between alignment and coverage probability that is comparable to our main estimates. For each quality measure, we find that coverage probability increases in quality. The association between quality measures and coverage probability is stronger than that of alignment and quality measures. This result reaffirms that quality affects coverage probability much more than alignment.

Table S4: Parametric Estimates of Alignment and Quality Association

Dependent Variable:	Coverage Probability				
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Variables					
Alignment	0.0004^{***}	0.0009^{***}	0.0008^{***}	0.0006^{***}	0.0001^{**}
	(6.41×10^{-5})	(6.43×10^{-5})	(6.42×10^{-5})	(6.53×10^{-5})	(6.53×10^{-5})
Academic Citations (log)	0.0092^{***}				
	(4.77×10^{-5})				
Research Grants (log)		$2.83 \times 10^{-5***}$			
		(5.81×10^{-6})			
Patents (log)			0.0039^{***}		
			(8.92×10^{-5})		
Journal Impact (log)				0.0047^{***}	
				(4.69×10^{-5})	
Quality (PCA)					0.0071^{***}
					(3.97×10^{-5})
Fixed-effects					
Field-Year	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Field-Outlet	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Fit statistics					
Observations	8,756,453	8,756,453	8,756,453	8,524,628	8,513,738
R^2	0.09634	0.09254	0.09273	0.09345	0.09578
Dependent variable mean	0.02055	0.02055	0.02055	0.02065	0.02066

IID standard-errors in parentheses
*Signif. Codes: ***: 0.01, **: 0.05, *: 0.1*

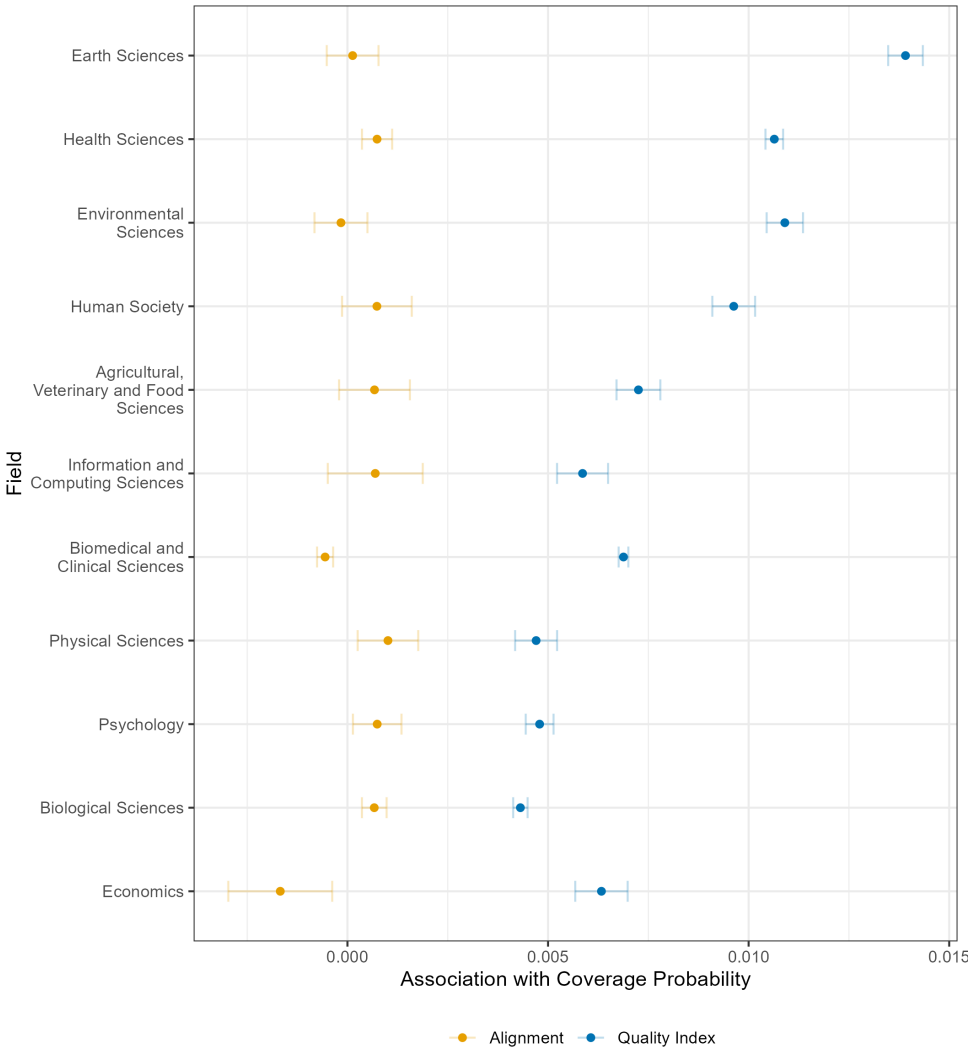
Notes: The table presents the parameter estimates of the linear probability model defined in Equation 2 for different quality measures. Each observation in the model is an outlet-paper pair. Alignment $a_q(I_o, I_p)$ is the standardized absolute value of the difference in the ideology of the paper and outlet. The quality measures are number of academic citations, amount of research grants, number of patent citations, and journal impact ($h-$index) for columns (1), (2), (3), and (4), respectively. We only include papers that were cited by at least one outlet. All columns include field-year and field-outlet fixed effects.

D.3 Quality association by field of science

In Figure S4 we present the association between coverage propensity and alignment alongside the association between coverage propensity and the quality index across fields of science. For each field, these associations are estimated simultaneously

using an LPM as in Equation 2.

Figure S4: Heterogeneity in alignment and quality associations by field of science



Notes: The figure presents the relationship between alignment and quality with media coverage for different fields of science. The $y-$axis represents a field of science. The $x-$axis presents the association between coverage propensity and alignment as well as quality, denoted by different colors. The alignment measure and quality index are normalized to have a mean of 0 and a standard deviation of 1.

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